SOCIAL LEARNING THEORY



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Expemo code:
1KA7-61LF-65A

1 Warm up

Read the definitions of two different ways we learn. Then discuss the questions.

- **Classical conditioning** - when we learn to associate one thing with another, even though they may not normally be connected
- **Operational conditioning** - when we learn the relationship between doing something and the result of doing it

In pairs decide if the following examples are Classical or Operational conditioning.

1. Your best friend often wears a particular perfume. You always have a great time together. While shopping one day without her, you smell the perfume in a shop and have a feeling of happiness. _____
2. You tell a joke to a group of friends. They all laugh really hard. You tell the same joke to a different group of friends. _____
3. You teach your dog to stand on his back legs by giving him a special dog biscuit he really likes every time he does it. _____
4. You eat a lot of ice cream before going on a long car ride. You get really sick in the car because it's a long journey and the road goes around a lot of bends. You don't eat ice cream for many years afterwards. _____

What information do you think you have learned from A. Classical conditioning and B. Operational conditioning?

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2 Focus on vocabulary

Part A: Match the vocabulary to the definitions.

1.	scold (v)	a.	feeling upset because you are unable to do what you want to do
2.	frustrated (adj.)	b.	when two or more things work together to achieve something and receive equal benefits from it
3.	imitate (v)	c.	gaining experience or knowledge from the actions of someone else
4.	aggressor (n)	d.	angrily tell someone they have done something wrong
5.	diminish (v)	e.	using mental abilities to understand something
6.	cognitive (adj.)	f.	copy what someone is doing
7.	reciprocal (adj.)	g.	a person who attacks someone or something
8.	vicarious (adj.)	h.	make something weaker or less effective

Part B: Now complete the following sentences with a different part of speech from the Part A word in brackets.

1. I remember receiving a real _____ when I cycled into my Dad's car and badly scratched it when I was eight. I've been nervous on a bike ever since. (scold)
2. I don't know why we keep buying this brand of peanut butter. The jars are _____ difficult to open. (frustrated)
3. I love this new handbag. It looks like it's a Christian Dior but it's actually an _____. (imitate)
4. The boys in my class have been acting really _____ lately and fighting a lot. I don't know what's wrong with them. (aggressor)
5. I believe social media has led to the _____ of people using their critical thinking abilities. (diminish)
6. Even though he'd seen her several times before, she displayed no signs of _____ when he entered the room. (cognitive)
7. She was really kind to me when I arrived and I wanted a chance to _____. (reciprocal)
8. He enjoyed living _____ through the photos she posted on Instagram, even though the chances of him going to those places was slim. (vicarious)

Now in pairs, discuss the following questions.

1. What behaviour did you used to get **scolded** for when you were a child?
2. What activities do you do which you feel improves your **cognitive** abilities?

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3 Watching for details

Watch the video (00:00-04:20) about social learning theory and answer the following questions.

1. What was the name of the psychologist who came up with the social learning theory?

   _____

2. When did he come up with it?

   _____

3. How many observations did the psychologist and his team make after the first experiment?

   _____

4. How many principles of the social learning theory did the psychologist eventually create?

   _____

4 Understanding the video

Part A: Complete the notes with one or two words from the video.

When Bandura started looking into social learning, the two main ideas of behaviour were classical and operational conditioning.

His experiment required a child to sit _____[1] and watch an adult attack a Bobo doll physically and verbally for _____[2]. After that, they went to another playroom where they weren't allowed to play with the toys they wanted. They then went back to the room where they were watched. Three observations were noted:

1. Children often _____[3] the behaviour of adults who had attacked the doll.

2. Girls were the aggressor with the doll _____[4] fewer than boys.

3. If an adult male attacked the doll, boys imitated them _____[5] many times than if it was a female adult, with girls also more likely to repeat the behaviour of adult females.



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Part B: Decide which of the following statements agree with the findings of Bandura in his social learning experiments.

1. ☐ No matter where children observe behaviour, they are likely to mirror it.
2. ☐ Films make children more aggressive than cartoons.
3. ☐ Children are less likely to act as an aggressor if they see someone being scolded for aggressive behaviour.
4. ☐ When we see people getting praised for good behaviour, it makes us much more likely to repeat that behaviour.
5. ☐ Social situations can be a place where children learn.
6. ☐ Watching behaviour as well as the consequences of that behaviour lead to learning.
7. ☐ Females learn more socially than males.
8. ☐ Children may learn without showing that they have learned or acting differently.
9. ☐ Our environment, our ability to mentally process the world around us, and behaviour of other people are all connected in our learning journey.

5 Reading for gist

Match the titles to paragraphs A - D. There are more titles than paragraphs.

1. Three methods
2. How social learning changed education
3. Possible problems with learning socially
4. Learning by observing
5. Four ways to understand
6. Uses for social learning



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Social learning

What it is and what it can do

A. _____

If you think back to your childhood, you can probably identify a few people who had a big impact on the way you thought and behaved. Friends, teachers, parents, or other people we come into contact with, can all have a big impact on the way we behave. The idea of social learning is that we observe what these people in our lives do and what the consequences of that behaviour are. Essentially, we all want to be accepted by the people around us, so the way we act is heavily influenced by that. This can affect our choice of clothes, career, partner and religion, amongst other things. If you grow up in the Middle East, it's less likely that you'll be a Buddhist. If your parents and grandparents worked for the military, it's liable that you will follow suit. Even when people go against expectations in this way, it is because they want to mark themselves as an outsider and are seeking approval from a different set of people.

B. _____

There are three main ways of observational learning. The first and most obvious is directly observing something. The Internet provides a way for us to solve problems we haven't dealt with before by offering us step by step guides from people who know how to do things we don't, from changing a plug to baking a lemon cake. Next there's symbolic learning. We all know stories from our childhood which vary from culture to culture, but often have similar messages. For example, the story of the Three Little Pigs, while outwardly about three pigs protecting themselves from the Big Bad Wolf, does carry an underlying message about laying solid foundations for your life and working hard. Finally, there's learning from verbal instructions. An example of this would be listening to a financial podcast with someone talking about how they invested their money.

C. _____

The fact that we are all individuals with different strengths and weaknesses can mean there are issues with this form of learning. Trying to emulate someone in a manner that's not natural to you can create a natural resistance and a loss of personal identity. When trying to copy someone who has skills that you lack, you can lose confidence. There can also be a potential negative effect on innovation. Doing something the way someone else does it doesn't necessarily mean it's the best way. Social learning requires following in someone's footsteps. That we have things such as the wheel, the computer and the car required someone to go where not only were there no footsteps, there was no path.

D. _____

Yet even with this in mind, there are many practical ways of applying social learning. Perhaps most obviously, it can be used in the classroom. Language teachers will regularly model what they want students to do, or how they should pronounce something, for example. The same applies to therapy, whether it's physical or psychological. Therapists are able to demonstrate what they want their patients to do to deal with their specific issue. Parents can also use it, both in obvious ways, such as teaching a child how to clean their shoes or indirect ways, such as the way they deal with money. Of course, this can work both ways as children often internalise parental attitudes without knowing. A parent who is careful with money or a parent who will buy luxury gifts but then not have enough for rent will both be sending messages to their children, even if they don't discuss money with them.

Sources: Valamis, Explore Psychology

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6 Reading comprehension

Read paragraphs A and B and decide if the following statements are True (T), False (F) or Not Given (NG).

1. We learn ideas and behaviours that will help us gain acceptance from the people around us. _____
2. Our religious beliefs are always a personal choice. _____
3. Even when we act differently from our peers, it's motivated by the need to be part of a group. _____
4. Learning by watching someone else doing something is the easiest way of acquiring knowledge. _____
5. Stories from childhood frequently carry hidden messages about the values of our society. _____

Part B: Read paragraphs C and D and complete the following sentences with no more than three words.

1. Having different _____ from those who we are trying to copy can cause problems with social learning.
2. One of the drawbacks of learning socially can be that we lose our _____ when we try to imitate behaviour that doesn't come naturally to us.
3. _____ can be less likely with this method of learning, as it usually requires doing things differently from what has already been established.
4. Both _____ and teachers, as well as parents, can demonstrate behaviour they want people to learn as a way to encourage learning.
5. We can often learn without realising, for example, from _____ towards finance.

Which two idioms in the article which use the verb 'follow' mean copying someone's behaviour?

_____

7 Talking point

In pairs, discuss the following questions.

1. Who had the most influence on you during the following ages? (0 - 8 years old; 8 - 12 years old; 12 - 18 years old)
2. Who do you think has the most effect on the way you behave now?
3. What skills have you learned from watching videos or listening to podcasts?
4. If you need to learn something new, what is your favourite way to do it?

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8 Extended activity/Homework

Part A: Find words in the article on page five which have the same meanings as the following definitions.

1. _____ likely (adj., para. A)
2. _____ someone who is not included in a group or society (n, para. A)
3. _____ representing an idea (adj., para. B)
4. _____ appearing to be something (adv., para. B)
5. _____ be under the surface of what can be easily seen or understood (adj., para. B)
6. _____ copy someone because they are doing something you want to do or admire (v, para. C)
7. _____ a refusal to do something (n, para. C)
8. _____ make an idea or behaviour a part of the way we act or think (v, para. D)

Part B: Write a short essay about who was the biggest influence on you as a child and what behaviours you learned from them.

Consider the following questions:

- Who was the person and what was their relationship to you?
- How did their behaviour stand out to you?
- What did you do to emulate that behaviour?
- What challenges were there in learning that behaviour?
- What were the results of learning, or not learning, that behaviour?

You should:

- Write at least 250 words
- Check your grammar, spelling and punctuation

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